

BEARDED DRAGON · *POGONA VITTICEPS*

Keep your bearded dragon the right way from day one.

A complete, checked-fact printable manual: setup, UVB, diet by age, health triage, and the routines that keep a dragon thriving for its full lifespan.

22 pages

Beginner to Intermediate

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 9 in order before buying anything. Housing, temperature, and UVB decisions are expensive to redo. Get the enclosure size and lighting right the first time, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 16 to buy once.

If your dragon is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Temperature Targets on page 14 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags section starting on page 10 if anything seems off.

Print these first

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Page 14: Setup Checklist & Temperature Targets | ☐ Page 19: Daily & Weekly Routine |
| ☐ Page 15: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 20: Owner Log |
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WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Bearded dragon husbandry has moved on from a lot of what older care sheets still say. This package reflects current UVB, enclosure-size, and diet standards, cross-checked against veterinary and herpetological sources, not recycled forum advice.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Pogona vitticeps</i>
Adult size	16 to 24 in (41 to 61 cm) nose to tail; 300 to 500 g
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years typical with consistent care, occasionally longer
Native range	Arid woodland and desert scrub, central Australia
Diet type	Omnivore, ratio shifts from insect-heavy to plant-heavy with age
Enclosure minimum (adult)	4×2×2 ft (≈120 gal), front-opening preferred
Handling difficulty	Beginner to intermediate; generally tolerant once settled
Conservation status	Least Concern (IUCN)

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$400 to \$800 for enclosure, UVB fixture, heating, substrate, and furnishings.

Monthly ongoing

\$50 to \$110 for feeder insects, greens, supplements, and bulb replacement averaged over the year.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

Emergency care isn't rare enough to ignore. Impaction surgery commonly runs \$800 to \$2,500; MBD treatment \$200 to \$500+. Neither is likely if you follow this package, but both are real enough to plan for.

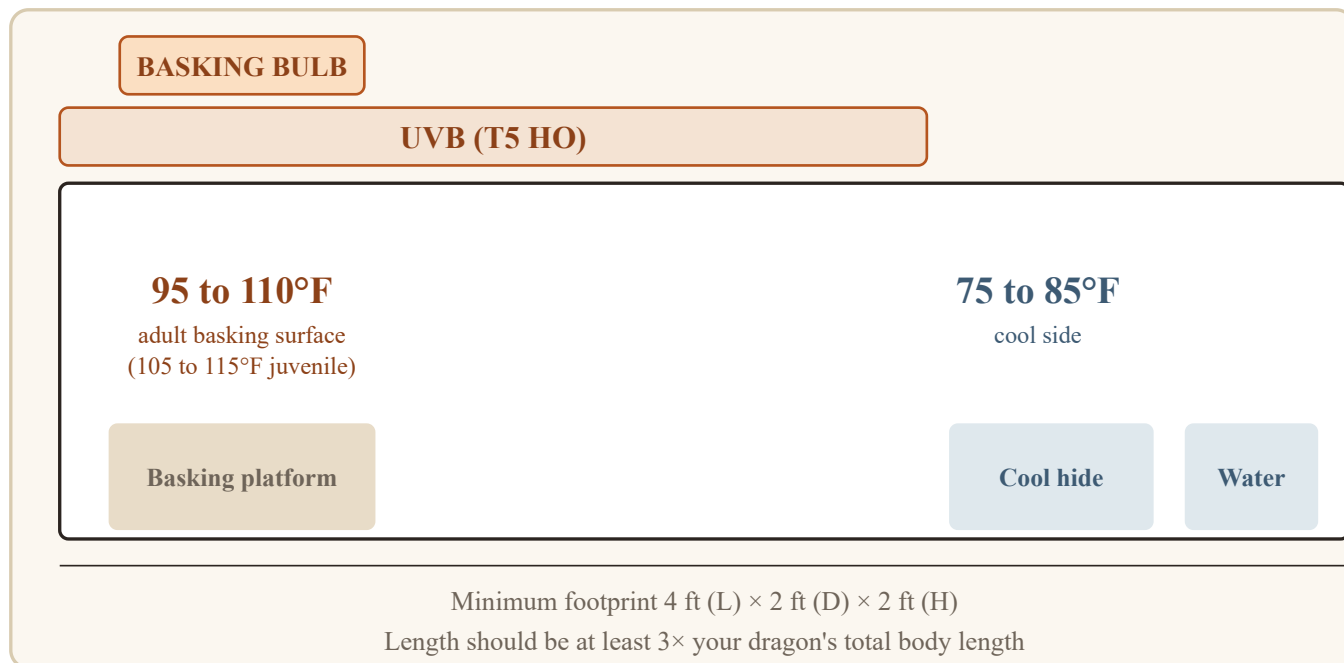
Fun facts worth knowing

- The "beard" is a flap of skin under the chin that darkens and puffs out during stress, territorial display, or breeding, not a sign of aggression by itself.
- Bearded dragons can shift their skin tone slightly to help regulate temperature, darkening to absorb more heat.
- They're one of the few reptiles that will readily wave a front leg in a slow circular motion, a social gesture between dragons.

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Housing & enclosure

4×2×2 ft (roughly 120 gallons) is the adult minimum, not an upgrade to get around to eventually. As a rule of thumb, enclosure length should be at least three times your dragon's total body length. A front-opening enclosure makes daily handling and cleaning far easier than a top-opening one.



NEVER

House two bearded dragons together. They are solitary and will stress, fight, or resource-guard even in large enclosures.

What the diagram doesn't show

- Cover three sides of the enclosure to cut down on reflections. A dragon that repeatedly mistakes its reflection for a rival can develop chronic stress.
- Skip hot rocks entirely. They're a common cause of thermal burns and add nothing a proper basking setup doesn't already do better.
- Two hides minimum: one warm-side, one cool-side, so your dragon never has to choose between security and temperature.

Temperature, UVB & humidity

ZONE	TARGET
Basking surface (adult / juvenile)	95 to 110°F / 105 to 115°F
Warm side (ambient, not basking)	~90°F
Cool side	75 to 85°F
Nighttime	65 to 75°F
Humidity	30 to 40% (arid species; higher humidity risks respiratory and skin infection)

Measure basking surface temperature with an infrared thermometer aimed at the actual platform, not the air above it. Only add overnight heat if the room regularly drops below ~65°F, and use a ceramic heat emitter rather than a light so it doesn't disrupt sleep.

Two fixtures, not one

UVB and heat are two separate jobs, this is the most common setup mistake. A T5 HO UVB tube provides UV but little usable heat on its own. Pair it with a separate basking bulb (halogen or incandescent, \$25 to \$50) over the same platform, and confirm the surface temperature with an infrared thermometer rather than trusting the bulb's wattage.

UVB is not optional

This is the one piece of equipment worth spending real money on. Use a linear T5 HO tube (ReptiSun 10.0 or Arcadia 12% Desert are commonly recommended), spanning roughly two-thirds of the basking-side enclosure length, mounted 12 to 18 inches from the basking surface, never behind glass or plastic. Both block UVB almost entirely.

UVI targets

Aim for a gradient from 0 up to **4.0 to 4.5** at the basking spot. If you keep a hypomelanistic, silkback, or translucent morph, dial this back to **3.0 or lower**. Those morphs are more UVB-sensitive and can be burned by standard output.

Bulb schedule

Run 10 to 14 hours a day. Replace every 6 to 12 months for T5, every 6 months for T8. Output drops well before the bulb visibly dims. Replace on schedule, not by appearance.

Signs your setup needs adjusting

YOU NOTICE	LIKELY MEANS
Glass fogging or condensation	Humidity running too high for the space
Stays on the highest perch, rarely basks	Basking spot too cool, or too far away
Digs at the coolest corner, gapes	Enclosure running too hot overall
Avoids the basking area entirely	UVI too strong, or surface too hot

Substrate, furnishings & handling

Substrate

Paper towel, newspaper, or tile are the safest options, especially while you're new to keeping dragons. Experienced keepers sometimes run a bioactive substrate (a deep naturalistic mix with live plants and a cleanup crew of isopods and springtails), but it's a bigger commitment and not where most people should start.

NEVER

Use loose sand (including calcium sand), wood chips, or gravel. All carry a real impaction risk if ingested. See page 11.

Furnishings checklist

- ☐ Basking platform (rock, slate, or sturdy wood) directly under the lamp
- ☐ Sturdy, well-anchored climbing branches
- ☐ Two hides: one warm side, one cool side
- ☐ Shallow water dish

Handling

Let a new dragon settle for several days before handling beyond feeding and cleaning. Support the full body, never the tail alone, and keep early sessions short. A dragon that flattens its body, darkens, gapes, or hisses is telling you to stop. End the session calmly rather than pushing through it.

BUILDING TRUST

Short, frequent, low-pressure handling sessions build tolerance faster than occasional long ones. Let the dragon walk onto your hand rather than grabbing from above, which reads as a predator strike.

First days in a new home

Newly arrived dragons, especially juveniles, stress more easily than settled adults. A rough timeline: days 1 to 3, hands-off except feeding and spot-cleaning; days 4 to 7, brief calm presence near the enclosure so your dragon gets used to your movement; week 2 onward, first short handling attempts if appetite and behavior look normal. Juveniles generally need shorter, more frequent sessions than adults, who tolerate longer handling once truly settled.

Diet & feeding by age

Bearded dragons are omnivores, and the ratio flips dramatically with age.

AGE	INSECTS	GREENS/VEG	FEEDING FREQUENCY
Juvenile (0 to 12 mo)	≈80%	≈20%	2 to 3× daily, as much as eaten in 10 to 15 min
Sub-adult (12 to 18 mo)	≈50%	≈50%	Once daily, transitioning down
Adult (18 mo+)	≈20%	≈80%	Greens daily; insects 3 to 5×/week

Supplement schedule

Calcium (with D3)

Dust every feeding for juveniles; 3 to 4× per week for adults.

Multivitamin

Once per week, all ages.

Gut-load feeder insects for 24 hours before offering them. This is what actually delivers most of the insects' nutritional value to your dragon. In practice: feed the insects themselves leafy greens, carrots, or a commercial gut-load product for a full day before they go into the enclosure.

NEVER FEED

Avocado, rhubarb, fireflies, wild-caught insects (pesticide risk), or insects wider than the space between your dragon's eyes, a common cause of impaction.

Hydration

Most hydration comes from food and regular misting, not from drinking out of a dish, many dragons barely touch standing water. Mist lightly a few times a week, and offer water-rich greens like cucumber or leafy greens as part of the normal diet.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Undersizing the enclosure "because it's just a baby," then never upgrading once it's an adult.
- Buying a UVB bulb once and never tracking its replacement date.
- Skipping the cool side entirely, leaving no way for the dragon to thermoregulate down.
- Feeding an adult like a juvenile, leading to obesity and fatty liver over time.
- Trusting packaging that says "reptile safe" without checking whether it's actually safe for this species specifically. Loose sand is the classic example.
- Skipping quarantine when introducing new decor or tools that have touched another reptile.
- Estimating UVI by eye instead of measuring it. Output can look bright while still being too weak, or too strong for a sensitive morph.

Enrichment, by priority

Climbing

Sturdy branches at varied heights encourage natural basking-ladder behavior and muscle use.

Dig box

A tray of digestible, damp substrate lets females exhibit natural nesting behavior even without breeding.

Visual security

Partial visual barriers, like plants or a half-covered side, let a dragon retreat from view without leaving the warm zone, which lowers baseline stress in high-traffic rooms.

Foraging

Scatter-feeding greens or letting insects roam the enclosure briefly engages natural hunting behavior.

Supervised free-roam

Short, supervised time outside the enclosure in a safe, warm room. Never unsupervised, never in a cold room.

Novelty rotation

Swapping or repositioning one furnishing every few weeks keeps the environment mentally engaging without a full teardown and rebuild.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

CONTACT A VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

Refusal to eat for 2+ weeks (outside brumation), sunken eyes, black beard combined with lethargy, limb swelling or limping, discharge from eyes/nose/mouth, persistent diarrhea, or straining without producing waste.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Current basking & cool-side temps, and UVB bulb age
- ☐ When symptoms started and whether they're worsening
- ☐ Diet breakdown (insects vs. greens) over the last 2 weeks
- ☐ Last normal bowel movement

Why UVB and temperature come up first

Most of the serious conditions in this section (MBD, respiratory infection, and appetite loss) trace back to a UVB or temperature problem more often than anything else. A vet will ask about your setup before anything else for exactly that reason.

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Black beard for a few hours during shedding, stress, or a territorial moment, then back to normal color	Black beard lasting multiple days, especially paired with lethargy or appetite loss
Skiping a meal occasionally, especially in cooler weather	Refusing food for 2+ weeks outside of a genuine brumation period
Brief lethargy right after a big meal or a shed cycle	Persistent lethargy with no clear trigger

Metabolic bone disease & impaction

Metabolic Bone Disease (MBD)

Cause: insufficient UVB or calcium relative to phosphorus, over time. **Signs:** soft or swollen jaw, bowed limbs, tremors, difficulty walking or lifting the body. **Diagnosis:** physical exam plus an X-ray to check bone density, sometimes a blood calcium panel. **Response:** vet diagnosis and treatment immediately. This does not self-correct and worsens quickly. Typical treatment cost runs \$200 to \$500+. **Recovery:** early, mild cases can improve over weeks to months with corrected UVB and vet-guided calcium therapy; advanced bone deformity often remains even after the disease itself is controlled.

PREVENTION BEATS TREATMENT

Correct UVB (page 6) and a consistent calcium/D3 schedule (page 8) prevent nearly all MBD cases. This is the single highest-leverage thing in this whole package.

Impaction

Cause: loose substrate, oversized feeder insects, or dehydration. **Signs:** straining without producing waste, visible lump along the belly, lethargy, loss of appetite. **Diagnosis:** physical palpation and an X-ray to locate and size the blockage. **Recovery:** mild, early cases sometimes resolve with vet-guided warm soaks and increased hydration; surgery is reserved for blockages that don't pass on their own.

CONCRETE THRESHOLD

If your dragon hasn't defecated in five or more days, it's time to see a vet. Don't wait longer to "see if it resolves." Surgery, when needed, commonly runs \$800 to \$2,500.

Respiratory infection, ADV & yellow fungus

Three conditions worth knowing by name before you ever see them.

Respiratory Infection (RI)

Cause: most often prolonged cool temperatures or excess humidity. **Signs:** open-mouth breathing, audible clicking or wheezing, mucus around the nose or mouth, lethargy. **Diagnosis:** physical exam and listening to the lungs; the vet will ask about your temperature setup directly. **Response:** vet visit for antibiotics; correct the temperature/humidity setup in parallel or it recurs.

Atadenovirus (ADV)

What it is: a viral infection, often introduced by an infected dragon or contaminated feeder insects/equipment. **Signs:** stunted growth, neurological symptoms, chronic poor condition despite correct husbandry. **Reality check:** there is no cure. Quarantine any new dragon for 60 to 90 days before introducing it to an existing collection, and never share feeder colonies between unknown-status dragons.

Yellow Fungus Disease (CANV)

What it is: a contagious fungal skin infection. **Signs:** yellow-brown discoloured, crusty, or thickened patches of skin, often starting on the head or limbs. **Diagnosis:** skin scrape and fungal culture. **Response:** antifungal treatment and isolation from other reptiles during treatment. It spreads by contact and shared substrate/tools.

THE COMMON THREAD

All three are far less common in a correctly heated, correctly lit, single-dragon enclosure with good quarantine hygiene for anything new. Prevention here is mostly husbandry, not luck.

Brumation, stuck shed & glass surfing

Brumation

A natural winter slowdown in appetite and activity, most common in adults. Signs include reduced eating, more time hiding, and lower activity over several weeks. Confirm with a vet check first to rule out illness, then let it happen naturally. Don't force feed during a genuine brumation. Typical brumation runs 4 to 8 weeks, occasionally longer; check in with a vet if it stretches past 3 months or comes with real weight loss, not just reduced activity.

Stuck shed (dysecdysis)

Most common on toes and the tail tip, where reduced humidity or blood flow interferes with normal shedding. Increase local humidity briefly with a damp towel or shallow soak, and never peel unshed skin by force. Toe and tail-tip stuck shed can cut off circulation if left unaddressed. A shallow, lukewarm soak two to three times a week during a shed cycle prevents most stuck-shed cases before they start.

Glass surfing

Repetitive pacing or scratching along the glass, usually a stress signal, often from seeing a reflection, another animal, or high foot traffic nearby. Cover reflective surfaces on three sides and reduce disruptive activity near the enclosure before assuming it's just "personality." Addressing the underlying trigger, more hides, a calmer room, less handling pressure, usually resolves it faster than covering glass alone.

QUICK DIFFERENTIATOR

Brumation is slow and low-energy. Glass surfing is repetitive and high-energy. If you're not sure which you're seeing, the energy level is usually the tell.

Setup checklist & temperature targets

Essential setup checklist

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ 4×2×2 ft enclosure, front-opening | ☐ Paper towel, newspaper, or tile substrate |
| ☐ Linear T5 HO UVB, 12 to 18in from basking spot | ☐ Shallow water dish |
| ☐ Separate basking bulb (UVB alone won't provide heat) | ☐ Calcium w/D3 + multivitamin supplements |
| ☐ Basking platform | ☐ Feeder insect setup or supplier |
| ☐ Infrared thermometer | ☐ UVB replacement date tracked |
| ☐ Two hides (warm + cool side) | |

Temperature & climate targets

TARGET	RANGE
Basking surface (adult / juvenile)	95 to 110°F / 105 to 115°F
Warm side (ambient, not basking)	~90°F
Cool side	75 to 85°F
Nighttime	65 to 75°F
Humidity	30 to 40%
UVI at basking spot	4.0 to 4.5 (3.0 or lower for sensitive morphs)

Before your dragon comes home

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Enclosure fully set up and running for 24 to 48 hours first | ☐ UVB fixture mounted at the correct distance and tested |
| ☐ Basking and cool-side temps confirmed with a thermometer, not by feel | ☐ Feeder insect and greens source lined up before day one |

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A REPTILE VET NOW IF

No bowel movement in 5+ days · open-mouth breathing or audible wheezing · limb swelling, tremors, or inability to lift the body · sunken eyes with lethargy · refusal to eat 2+ weeks outside brumation

READING	TARGET
Basking surface (adult / juvenile)	95 to 110°F / 105 to 115°F
Warm side (ambient, not basking)	~90°F
Cool side	75 to 85°F
Nighttime low	65 to 75°F
Humidity	30 to 40%
UVI at basking spot	4.0 to 4.5 (3.0 sensitive morphs)
UVB bulb replacement	Every 6 to 12 months (T5) · every 6 months (T8)

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Basking & cool-side temps, UVB bulb age, last bowel movement, and diet over the last two weeks.

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget & shopping list

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
4×2×2 ft enclosure	\$150 to \$350
Linear T5 HO UVB fixture + bulb	\$60 to \$110
Basking bulb + fixture	\$25 to \$50
Thermostat / infrared thermometer	\$25 to \$45
Substrate, hides, dish, decor	\$60 to \$120
Initial vet check	\$50 to \$100
Total initial setup	\$400 to \$800
Feeder insects (monthly)	\$25 to \$50
Greens/veg (monthly)	\$10 to \$25
Supplements + bulb replacement (averaged)	\$15 to \$35
Monthly ongoing	\$50 to \$110

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

Impaction surgery \$800 to \$2,500 · MBD treatment \$200 to \$500+. A small emergency fund matters as much as any item on this list.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The UVB fixture and enclosure size are the two line items most directly tied to the health conditions in this package. Save on decor and extras before you save here.

First 30 days checklist

Week 1

- ☐ Confirm all temperatures and UVI with an actual thermometer/meter, not "feels warm"
- ☐ Let your dragon settle: minimal handling, focus on feeding and observing appetite
- ☐ Schedule a wellness vet visit within the first two weeks

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Begin short, gentle handling sessions if appetite and behavior look normal
- ☐ Establish a consistent feeding and supplement schedule
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 20

Week 4

- ☐ Review weight trend from the Owner Log. Steady gain is the goal for a juvenile
- ☐ Mark your UVB bulb's replacement date on a calendar
- ☐ Introduce first enrichment items from page 21

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book the follow-up wellness check most vets recommend after initial setup
- ☐ Re-measure UVI directly if you have access to a meter, don't rely on the bulb's age alone
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for any slow drift in weight, appetite, or temps
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 21

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Black beard + lethargy	Stress, illness, or brumation	Check temps first; vet if persistent
No bowel movement 5+ days	Impaction	Vet promptly (page 11)
Soft/swollen jaw, tremors	Metabolic bone disease	Vet immediately (page 11)
Open-mouth breathing, wheezing	Respiratory infection	Vet promptly (page 12)
Yellow/crusty skin patches	Yellow fungus (CANV)	Vet + isolate (page 12)
Stuck shed on toes/tail	Low humidity or blood flow	Damp towel/soak (page 13)
Repetitive glass scratching	Stress / reflection	Cover sides (page 13)
Reduced appetite, adult, cooler months	Possible brumation	Vet check first, then let it happen (page 13)
Sudden weight loss between log entries	Several possible causes	Vet visit, bring the Owner Log (page 20)
Persistent diarrhea	Parasites, diet, or stress	Vet visit, stool sample if possible

Daily & weekly routine

Daily

- ☐ Check basking & cool-side temps
- ☐ Feed per the age-based schedule on page 8
- ☐ Refresh water dish
- ☐ Quick visual health check: eyes, beard, posture, appetite

Weekly

- ☐ Spot-clean substrate and wipe down glass
- ☐ Weigh and log in the Owner Log
- ☐ Rotate or refresh one enrichment item
- ☐ Confirm UVB bulb is still within its replacement window

Monthly

- ☐ Full substrate change and enclosure deep clean
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends, not just single readings
- ☐ Check that furnishings still fit your dragon's current size

Seasonal

- ☐ Reassess room temperature swings between summer and winter
- ☐ Watch for early brumation signs in cooler months (page 13)

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Owner log

Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT	BASKING °F	COOL °F	APPETITE	NOTES

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

A steady weight trend is the single best early warning system you have. Most of the conditions in this package show up as a weight change before anything else is visible.

Bulb & equipment log

ITEM	INSTALLED	REPLACE BY
UVB bulb		
Basking bulb		
Thermometer/hygrometer batteries		

Vet visit log

DATE	REASON	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ Varied-height climbing branches, securely anchored
- ☐ Digestible dig-box substrate area
- ☐ At least two hides at different enclosure temperatures

Monthly review

- ☐ Rotate or reposition one furnishing to refresh the layout
- ☐ Offer scatter-feeding or supervised free-roam at least once
- ☐ Reassess whether climbing/basking items still fit current body size

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT

Glossary

Brumation	A reptile's natural winter dormancy period: reduced activity and appetite, distinct from illness.
Dysecdysis	Incomplete or "stuck" shedding, most often affecting toes and the tail tip.
Gut-loading	Feeding nutritious food to feeder insects before offering them, so the nutrition passes through.
Impaction	A gastrointestinal blockage, often from substrate or oversized prey.
MBD	Metabolic Bone Disease: weakened bones from inadequate UVB or calcium.
UVI	UV Index: the measurement scale used to describe basking-spot UVB intensity.
CANV	<i>Nannizziopsis vriesii</i> , the fungus behind Yellow Fungus Disease.
ADV	Atadenovirus: an incurable viral infection; prevention relies on quarantine.
Quarantine	Keeping a new or unwell reptile fully separate from others, including separate tools and hand-washing between handling, to prevent disease spread.

Compiled from veterinary and herpetological sources, cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. This package is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for a reptile-experienced veterinarian, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

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